

Redemption

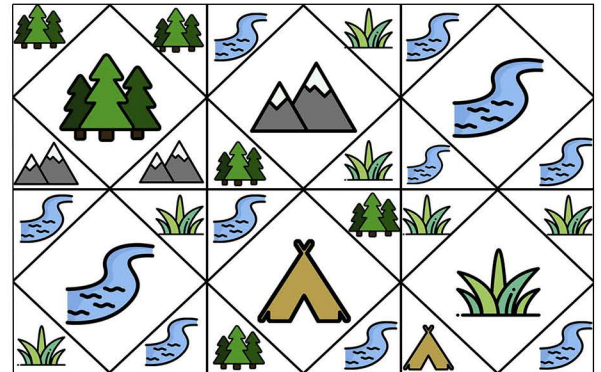
You have been exiled from the tribe for violating its taboos, as the gods are about to unleash a great flood as punishment. In order to ensure the safety of your people, you embark on a journey of redemption, facing the perils of the wilderness. Before the flood arrives, you must offer sufficient resources to the gods and seek their forgiveness.

GOAL:

To win, you must survive and successfully offer sacrifices.

GAME COMPONENTS:

1. 5 six-sided dice (for counting)
2. 16 Terrain cards
3. 10 Opportunity cards
4. 7 yellow tokens (health resource)
5. 7 purple tokens (crystal resource)
6. 7 green tokens (food resource)
7. 7 red tokens (party resource)



Heavy fog	Plague
Action points -1 for next turn	Health-1 Party-1 OR Food-1 Purple-1

This point system can help you keep track of how many actions you have each turn; you can have a maximum of 6 actions (increased by red tokens).

SETUP:

1. Shuffle the **Terrain cards** and **Opportunity cards**, and place them face down.
2. Draw a **Terrain card**, place it face up, and place a die on it with point 3 showing.
3. Take one of each type of token and arrange them in your desired order from left to right.
4. Assign 4 dice to the 4 types of tokens in step 3. Then roll the dice to assign them new **random numbers**.

The number here indicates the victory condition, not the recurring resource requirement per turn.

5. Immediately gain resources from the terrain beneath your starting position.

THIS IS WHAT YOUR GAME SHOULD LOOKS LIKE:

TERRAIN CARDS & MOVEMENTS:

Terrain cards have 5 spaces with terrain symbols. 4 are in the corners of the card, and 1 is in the center. Whenever you move to a space, you **must** obtain the corresponding item. *For example*, if you move to a space with mountain symbol, draw 1 **Opportunity card**. If you move to a forest, increase the corresponding token(food) by 1. Once you leave a **Terrain card**, flip it face down. You can't get any more resources from it.

Grassland - Obtain 1 **opportunity card**

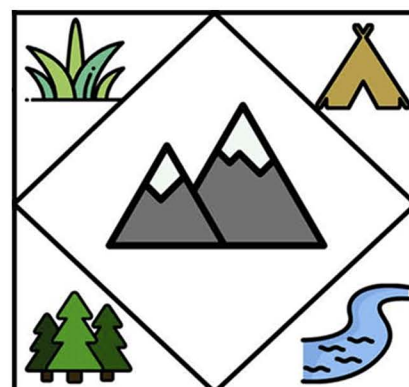
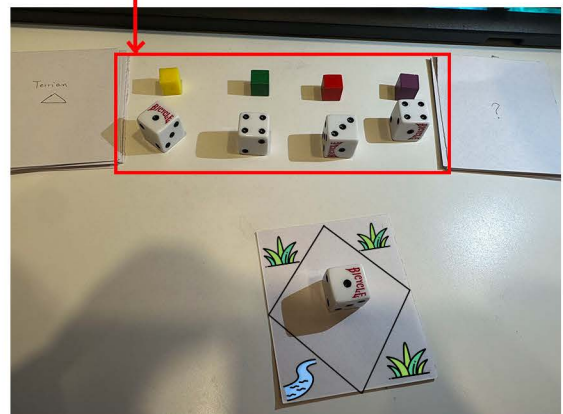
Mountain - Obtain 1 **purple token**

River - Obtain 1 **red token**

Settlement - Obtain 1 **yellow token**

Forest - Obtain 1 **green token**

Blank terrain - NO resources

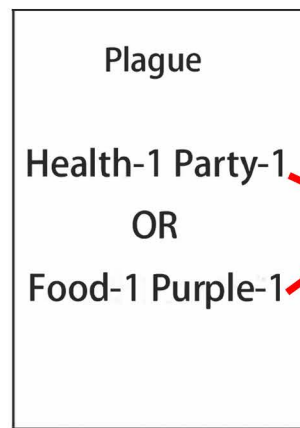


OPPORTUNITY CARDS:

Draw an **Opportunity card** when you land on a settlement space. Some **Opportunity cards** have only 1 effect, while others allow you to choose from multiple effects listed on the card.

The effect triggers IMMEDIATELY upon drawing!

*Once all **Terrain cards** or **Opportunity cards** of a certain type have been drawn, shuffle those exhausted cards back into the deck. Then, you can continue drawing from the deck.



TOKENS:

1. **Red tokens** represent the **blood**. Start at 0. The gods hunger for your blood! Go to the riverside to offer sacrifice! But beware, after 6 offerings, if you don't win, you'll perish, and the game ends.
2. **Purple tokens** represent **crystal**. Spend two to increase or decrease the number of any token.
3. **Green tokens** represent **food**. When all action points are consumed, players enter the eating phase. Players initially need only one food token. However, with red tokens, each additional food token is required.
4. **Yellow tokens** represent your **party**. Each **yellow token** grants 1 additional action point.
 - After all tokens have been used up, you can **no longer** obtain new tokens unless you use up some.
 - The **maximum** limit for each token is 6. The 4 tokens used during **SETUP** are only for reference and cannot be obtained.

GAME PROCESS:

1. Move and Collect:

- Players start with 3 actions points. Each movement consumes 1 action point. Players must collect the corresponding token or **Opportunity card** when landing on a space.
- Players' movements **must** pass through the center of a **terrain card**. *For example:* you can move from a corner to the center, center to center, or center to corner. However, you **CANNOT** move from one corner directly to another corner.
- Players can choose to draw a new **Terrain card** and move to the center of the new card while taking their action. This also consumes 1 action point.
- The new card can be placed in any of the 4 adjacent positions to the existing card, but the orientation of the card **cannot be rotated**.

2. **Eating:** After actions are depleted, players must eat, with the amount equal to the number of the **yellow token** you have NOW (**party**).

- Sufficient food:** Action points are restored, and the game proceeds to the next turn.
- Insufficient food:** For each missing **food**, lost 1 **yellow token**.
If you lack sufficient food for 2 consecutive turns, the game ENDS in failure.

HOW TO START

1. Set up the game →
 2. Move to new terrain →
 3. Collect corresponding resources.
→ 4. Eat after action points used up. →
 5. Repeat steps 2-4 until victory or failure.
- #If the deck runs out of cards, check the instructions under '[Opportunity Cards](#)' for details

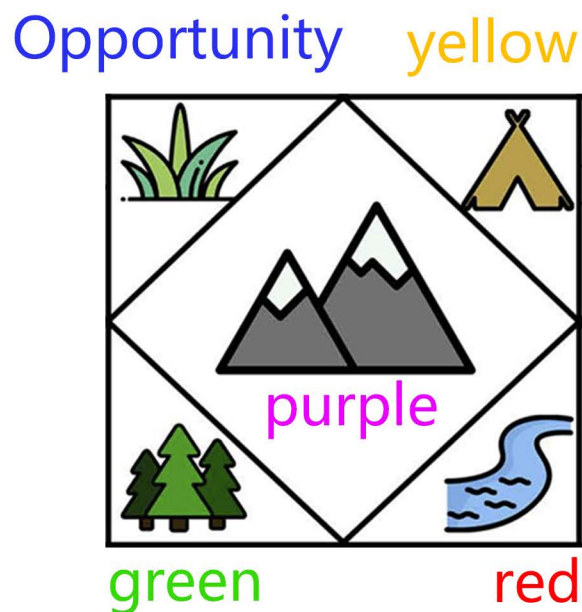
FAILURE CONDITIONS

1. Not having enough food for two consecutive turns.
2. Failing to meet the victory condition when obtaining 6 **red tokens**.

VICTORY CONDITION

At any time, when the number of each type of token is **greater than or equal** to the corresponding number rolled in **SETUP step 4**, you won.

(This means you have gathered the sacrifices and successfully offered them.)



by Rui Zi

Design Rationale

The main purpose of designing this game is to provide players with a relaxing yet strategic gaming experience. Additionally, I aim to ensure that players encounter different gameplay experiences each time they play, while maintaining the game's replayability and simplicity.

One significant gameplay element is the random setting of victory conditions, which injects a unique experience into each game session. In the game, I set specific victory conditions such that each token possessed by a player must have a higher point value than the randomly rolled value at the beginning of the round. Players roll dice at the start of each round to randomize the victory conditions, shaping their gameplay style and strategy for that session. Furthermore, the variety in terrain cards ensures the game remains lightweight and strategic, with just ten cards offering over ten thousand possible decisions.

The integration of random victory conditions merges diverse gaming experiences with strategic elements. I introduced four interrelated types of tokens. For instance, the more yellow tokens a player has, the faster their green tokens deplete, but they also gain more actions per turn. Therefore, if the victory condition randomly requires more green tokens and fewer yellow tokens, players need to avoid acquiring yellow tokens to win with limited actions. Conversely, players need to ensure they do not suffer from a shortage of green tokens, utilizing numerous actions to obtain enough resources for a decisive victory.

These victory conditions align well with the game's background. Players portray exiled tribespeople, with victory conditions revolving around offering various items as sacrifices to the deities. The randomness symbolizes the inscrutable will of the deities, presenting players with uncertain victory conditions in each session. Additionally, the condition of player death due to an excess of yellow tokens represents the need for players to sacrifice themselves while ensuring they stay alive to gather offerings, thus penalizing players for an excess of resources.

Designer's Diary

REDEMPTION is a lightweight game, possibly taking only around 10 minutes to complete a session. However, initially, I set an overly ambitious goal during conceptualization, to the extent that it might take me a year to accomplish. As a fan of survival games, I emulated various game features, including craftable items, challenging random events, and even complex combat mechanisms that are hard to implement in board games. About a month and a half ago, I realized this mistake and had to abandon most of the mechanisms, opting for a more lightweight approach. It was the biggest mistake I made during the design process.

Upon realizing the overly ambitious goal, I had to improve the mechanisms based on what was already completed, ensuring the game did not become bloated while maintaining its gameplay. At the time, I had completed complex terrain and resource cards, and even determined random victory conditions. However, due to their complexity, I struggled to articulate them clearly in the rules. Hence, I decided to start modifying the terrain cards.

Simplifying Terrain Cards:

Initially, I designed the terrain cards in a snowflake pattern, with each card having seven grids, similar to the terrain cards in the board game "Magic Knight" (as shown).



However, this design required more terrain cards to achieve diverse landscapes. Additionally, creating a game board was cumbersome, as I needed paper much larger than A4 size, which was challenging to find.

To address these issues, I directly replaced the snowflake-shaped terrain cards with squares, with each type of terrain corresponding to one grid in the middle and four corners. This reduced the number of terrain cards required to represent multiple terrains. Moreover, the square design prevents players from feeling confused about how to connect the terrain, and the game can even be played without a game board.

Adjusting Token Mechanics:

Initially, I set tokens as raw materials for crafting items, some of which could fulfill victory conditions. However, this was too complex for a board game, prone to confusion and challenging to explain in the rules. The plethora of cards also exceeded the seven-page limit for the game content.

To address the complexity and excessive content, I removed the crafting mechanic, merging raw materials with victory conditions. However, I soon encountered another problem: tokens became redundant without the crafting utility, as players only needed to continuously explore terrain cards to win. Therefore, I reintegrated elements like health and food into tokens, and introduced new consumption mechanisms. For instance, at the end of each round, players must consume food, depleting green tokens representing food. Red tokens represent health, yellow tokens represent party members, which intensifies food consumption, leading to penalties for a shortage of food. Additionally, I introduced a minor crafting formula for purple tokens, allowing any two purple tokens to be converted into another type of token. Consequently, the strong correlation among tokens adds depth to the game's strategy.

Modify the mechanism of Tokens:

In the beginning, I set tokens as raw materials for crafting items, some of which could fulfill victory conditions. However, this complexity proved cumbersome for a board game, leading to confusion and difficulty in explaining the rules. The abundance of cards also made my game content exceed seven pages.

To address the complexity issue, I removed crafting altogether, merging raw materials and victory conditions. But this created another problem: without crafting, tokens had no purpose beyond exploration. Players could win by continuously exploring terrain cards. To counter this, I combined health, food, and other aspects. Tokens now have new consumption mechanics—for instance, green tokens represent food and are consumed at the end of each turn. Red tokens signify health, yellow represents party members, intensifying food consumption but risking loss due to scarcity. Purple tokens gained a minor crafting recipe, allowing any two purple tokens to transform into another type. This interdependence adds strategic depth to the game.

Post-playtest adjustments: After implementing the changes, playtesters in the workshop quickly identified another issue: players could obtain all necessary resources from a few terrain cards. To address this, I adjusted resource distribution—fewer cards now contain multiple resources. I also modified movement rules. Previously, players could move between any adjacent tiles; now, they must pass through the center tile of a terrain card and cannot revisit previously left tiles. These changes encourage exploration and discourage conservative play.

Final adjustments:

I further refined game settings and rules. Initially, red tokens represented player health, but having more red tokens led to death, confusing testers. I reimagined them as blood, where victory required sacrificing to the gods, but excessive sacrifice risked death.

During the last playtest, testers expressed confusion about my rules. Fortunately, their feedback guided improvements, although writing rules remained challenging. Unfortunately, I lost my red tokens, substituting white ones instead, hoping it wouldn't cause too much confusion.

By the way, the random victory conditions were inspired by a joke shared with my girlfriend and friends. While my friends found it amusing, she was furious. This contrast reminded me of the capricious gods in the game's lore, leading me to randomize victory conditions—each game features a different god with unique standards. I'm grateful to my TA and professor for their relentless guidance and rigorous evaluation criteria, which helped me improve the game significantly and taught me valuable lessons.